finishing after 1.15 a.m. The entire crew and audience now wanted ‘selfies’ with their hero!

Next Thursday, the TRP figures were out. Modi’s show, aired on a Saturday night at 10 p.m., was by far the number one show, getting almost 70 per cent audience share. ‘We were stunned with the numbers. It was by far the highest we had got for any *Aap Ki Adalat* programme,’ says Rajat.

At the same time the Modi programme was playing out, Aaj Tak, the leading Hindi news channel, was airing a Rahul Gandhi interview. It barely registered on the TRP meter. The Modi interview had 7 million views on YouTube by the time the elections were over. It was repeated seven times (often just before a major election day) and the viewership kept soaring.

And yet, there was a question mark over whether the interview had been stage-managed. Rajat insists that he asked Modi all the hard questions and the audience wasn’t tutored to cheer for the BJP’s prime ministerial nominee. ‘The fact is Modi is simply the finest political communicator I have seen since Vajpayee. He knew how to reach out to an audience, it was all spontaneous,’ he says.

But the India TV editorial director Qamar Waheed Naqvi did not agree. The morning after the show was telecast, he resigned. ‘The entire programme was part of the Modi propaganda machine. No hard questions were asked and the audience was full of Modi *bhakt*s who were only there to cheer for him,’ he told me later.

Rajat denies the accusations, saying Naqvi was fully aware of the programme content and had actually praised it after it was recorded. ‘I think the AAP members got to Naqvi and forced him to resign, and tried to make a political issue out of it,’ he claims. Rajat’s proximity to Modi meant that his neutrality would always be questioned by his critics. But it’s also true that lines are often crossed when a journalist gets too close to a politician.

Whatever the truth, the fact is the interview was a blockbuster. If the Rahul interview forced the Congress leader to retreat, Modi’s India TV programme only added to the aura around him. Over the next twenty-eight days—between 12 April and 10 May—Modi did almost fifty print and